

Episode 141: *The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes Volume 2

I've started going to a new studio this month for the first time to prepare for a certain TV series. The equipment is already set up and we're waiting for work to begin in earnest.

As always, what bothers me every time is the height of the desk and chair. I don't have very good posture, and I tend to become quite hunched over when sitting and working. This isn't good, you know, especially for the back. So I consciously set the desk surface quite high and the chair seat low, creating a balance that forces my back to straighten whether I like it or not.

However, the chairs at this studio aren't very good (bitter laugh). They're all quite worn out, so the director and animation director bought their own chairs and brought them in. And honestly, I'm considering it too. Until that's decided, I can't determine the desk height either. I've prepared wooden blocks to place under the desk legs for height adjustment just in case.

So what should I do? For now, I'll try out the studio chairs and see how it goes. So today, I decided to buy a cushion when I go to the studio (laugh).

Anyway.

This week's "*The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes" continues. Episodes 3-5 from DVD & Blu-ray Volume 2.

Episode 3: Cycling Club "Soleil"

Storyboard/Direction/Animation Director: Makihara Ryotaro, Animation Director: Asano Naoyuki, Colour Direction (色指定): Otsuka Natsuko

Schedule-wise, Episode 3 felt like it was being worked on almost parallel with Episode 2. Episode 4 was actual work after Episode 1 was mostly formed, but when we were making Episodes 2 and 3, Episode 1 was still in production. We progressed with quite a bit of exploration about how the visuals would develop.

Episode 3 has more of "I's" delusions than Episode 2. Past recollections, present, and delusions. Broadly divided, the first half part where his bicycle is stolen and he tells the story up to that point is past recollection, and the latter half, where he returns home dejected, and then from the "Shimanami Cup" is the current timeline. And then delusions.

As I wrote in Episode 2, we make the past recollections recognisable by making the main line colours sepia-toned brown, but we also tried changing the main line colours in various ways for the delusion scenes. And furthermore, we differentiated by making characters other than "I" colourful monotonous. The exploratory feeling actually remains in such places, and you can see an atmosphere where we're still holding back a bit. This becomes much clearer in the latter half of the series, but in Episode 3, we still lacked a bit of boldness, I think.

What worked quite well though was the silhouette processing of background characters (モブ). The other players in the bicycle race, spectators, bicycles and parts at the bicycle shop. In this episode, we were able to establish the rules for background character silhouette processing almost completely. "Background characters" refers to passersby, shop customers, and all those other masses of characters.

As I wrote before, I consider the basic stance to be that we're watching from relatively close to the protagonist "I" as he mutters to himself. So people (or things) that "I" isn't directly involved with right now are given thorough silhouette processing since "I" himself isn't interested in them, while people (or things) that "I" is talking to or handling are given colour. By doing this, the things related to "I" become coloured and clear. This became the major principle going forward.

For example, in the bicycle shop scene. The bicycles and parts placed around or hung on walls are single-colour silhouettes. But the parts "I" is holding are coloured. Also, for instance, in the recollection scene of Akashi-san's victory press conference. "I" and Akashi-san are coloured, while the press corps and surrounding spectators are single-colour silhouettes. That's how it works.

The colour direction (色指定) for Episode 3 was done by Otsuka Natsuko-san. She participated while working on a certain theatrical film scheduled for spring release. She gave quite bold colour direction, and I left the silhouette colour tones almost entirely to Otsuka-san. This sensibility would be fully demonstrated again later in Episode 6.

In Episode 3, there's one scene - well, it's not a failure, but I have some regrets about it - the scene with "I" and Akashi-san during the race at Keage. It's the scene at the magnificent Incline with cherry blossoms. Director Yuasa apparently wanted this to be like the evening scenes in Tadasu Forest used in Episodes 1 and 2, but that would have been problematic timing-wise, so it ended up being a daytime scene. However, to make it a "special scene," we made the main lines pink and finished it in colours that felt pink-purple. But looking back now, ah, I should have gone more boldly with the colouring. From that reflection, or lesson, came the pink-tinted colouring for "I" and Akashi-san that appeared several times from Episode 4 onward - hair also made pink, becoming the pink version of Episode 1's evening colours.

Episode 4: Seeking Disciples

Storyboard/Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Colour Direction: Suzuki Hisako

Episode 4's direction was by Yokoyama-san. Following Episode 2 with Episode 4, and moreover, quite a heavy episode in terms of volume. Time was quite tight and it was tough (laugh). Colour direction was by Suzuki Hisako-san. She was the colour designer (色彩設計) for "Stray Cat Overrun!" which was airing at the same time, but I really forced her to take this on despite her busy schedule.

This episode basically follows the current timeline, with past recollections interspersed throughout.

There are so many scenes, hence many detailed colour changes, plus props and one-off items, and incomprehensible delusional depictions (laugh) appearing all over the screen. Even the same four-and-a-half-mat room - Master Higuchi's room is extremely cluttered, making the art department's job difficult enough, but then it's night, day, evening, or even imaginary, with every possible colour variation existing. Moreover, it's a storm of combined layout and animation cuts. Combined cuts spanning multiple colour changes made it a nightmare for the colour direction staff (←actually, later episodes would become even more difficult...).

I prepare the colour tones for broadly divided scenes, but there were many things that depended on the animation on a cut-by-cut basis rather than scene basis. For now, we had the colour direction staff colour things based on our meetings, then I'd check and make necessary corrections - this back-and-forth was probably the most frequent in the series. This episode also featured many famous Kyoto specialties. The cockroach cubes also appeared in this episode, and Episode 10, where cockroaches appeared again, also ended up assigned to Suzuki-san. Pure coincidence (laugh).

The evening scene at Kamogawa Delta. The image scene where the delta rises up as Master Higuchi sings and becomes the Nautilus - after the animation came up and we had it coloured temporarily, Yokoyama-san and I worked it out together, then sent it back to the colour direction staff for refinement.

The climactic "confrontation" scene was tough again, with the cut showing historical representatives appearing on both shoulders. This was difficult in terms of finishing (仕上げ), and Suzuki-san literally had to work on the cel data sheet by sheet to complete it somehow.

Incidentally, the master's hammock was actually animation, and we pasted in chiyogami paper material used for backgrounds for the net parts, which the photography team processed nicely. I did all this pasting myself. For some reason, the workflow developed that way, and I painstakingly transformed materials to match the animation. This was surprisingly fun (laugh). So ultimately, all this work became my responsibility (laugh).

Oh yes, the pink colouring for "I" and Akashi-san I wrote about in the Episode 3 section appears in the scene where "I" and Akashi-san, who were wandering in search of the phantom scrub brush, meet at Nishiki Market.

Episode 5: Softball Circle "Honwaka"

Storyboard: Hamasaki Hirofumi, Direction: Takahashi Tomoya, Animation Director: Ishihama Masashi, Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The end of the first half is this suspicious "Honwaka." From escaping the Honwaka headquarters onward is the present; everything before that is past recollection.

This Episode 5 was also quite a troublesome episode, and like Episode 4, involved considerable back-and-forth where the colour direction staff would colour things and I'd check them. Colour direction was by Akimoto-san, her second time.

Episode 5 features many "Honwaka" members, but aside from image scenes and some depth effects, basically we didn't silhouette the "Honwaka" members. They were all tied together with yellow "Honwaka" T-shirts and patches, so I thought it might be better for each individual to have some colour variation. And since both the animation and colouring were designed to lack much individuality, I thought not silhouetting them might better bring out that "creepy feeling of a mass without personality." Instead, we thoroughly silhouetted ordinary people.

Kohinata-san was supposed to wear yellow according to the director, so her dress is yellow. Since she's a "black-haired maiden," she has black hair. To differentiate her from other people, her skin and face have no outline colours - everything is the same white. Since the setting was to not draw eyes or nose, this created a nice sense of presence.

Including this Kohinata-san, the past recollection in the first half has both art and colouring arranged in an overall bright, soft, gentle screen, but from when "I" arrives at the "Honwaka" headquarters, following "I's" suspicion and danger signals, it gradually flows into darker colour usage. The primary colours of black, green, and blue coming from nozzles in the pure white factory look great. I had Akimoto-san handle this area more and more.

The "brainwashing scene" with drifting pink smoke. The colours of people "popping!" and bursting had already formed in my mind during the art board meeting, and after creating samples with actual cuts and getting approval from director Takahashi-san, I had Akimoto-san compile them with "please make it like this."

A little before completion, we all watched it through with dialogue and sound, and wow, the Honwaka chairman's speech was magnificent - gave me goosebumps watching it.

At the end, "the 'I' from Episode 10" appears from the window. Like the "100,000 yen" from Episode 4, we creators had a "grin" feeling of "how will viewers react to this?" (laugh).

I'm writing this while rewatching the DVD footage, and the completely dark forest scenes at the beginning and latter half were beautifully dark even on the video check monitor, making me worry "Is this okay? Won't it be invisible on TV?" I think this was ultimately just barely acceptable? Did we adjust it slightly brighter during V-editing? I'm not sure.

The schedule was already getting quite tight from around Episode 5. But thinking back, maybe this area still had plenty of room...

(10.10.19)